

iQOO 12

Best iQOO camera in a matured package

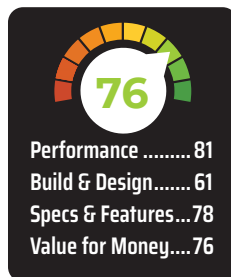
iQOO is back with another flagship, and like every year, this year also the company has got the first mover advantage, effectively setting a benchmark. The iQOO 12 is the first smartphone in India to come with the Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Gen 3 chipset, just like the iQOO 11 was the first smartphone to launch with the Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Gen 2 last year right before the New Year. But has iQOO finally got things right in terms of offering a complete flagship experience? Let's find out:

DESIGN

The first thing everyone notices in a smartphone is the design. With the iQOO 12, the brand has finally taken a new design approach. Ever since the iQOO 7 series, we have seen different implementations of the same BMW M-Motorsport racing stripes. This year, the brand has gone away from that design and given a fresh look to the 2024 flagship. We get a plain white glass back panel, with a square-ish camera module that the brand is calling a "Porthole" design, inspired by a spaceship or a submarine window.

We still get the BMW M Motorsport branding, but this time it is more subtle. The blue, black, and red stripes are limited to a tiny area right next to the iQOO branding with the "Fascination Meets Innovation" tagline. The LED flash is also placed on the back panel next to the camera module.

Up front, things are familiar. There is a hole-punch display, and the receiver is placed right above the screen, merging into the super slim bezels. While we are on bezels, this is the thinnest bezel that we have ever seen on any iQOO smartphone, with a width of just 1.54mm. Overall also, the iQOO 12 is also pretty slim by flagship



standards. The smartphone measures just 8.1mm in thickness so the in-hand feel of this smartphone is quite nice, despite that rather large size. However, the smartphone feels heavy to me. It's not heavy by flagship standards at 207 grams, but since I

use a compact smartphone as my primary, the iQOO 12 felt slightly heavy.

So in terms of design, the iQOO 12 is a good departure from the brand's usual design language that we have been seeing for at least the last three years. It is absolutely brand new, but doesn't go too far away from identifying it as an iQOO flagship. I also liked the previous design, but it was time iQOO went away from the blue, black and red stripes. iQOO tells us that the brand tested 2239 designs to come up with this and by looking at it, this is a good upgrade to the standard design we have seen in the last few flagships.

DISPLAY

Coming to the display, this is also where iQOO is claiming big numbers. While there are a lot of claims and numbers talk around the display, things are subject to test. And testing I did.

First, let's talk about the colours. The panel on the iQOO 12 is a 10-bit display so we can expect a wide range of colours, but how accurate are these? I put the iQOO 12's display through the Calman Colour Checker, and the smartphone showed brilliant accuracy. The iQOO 12 showcased an average DeltaE or error of just 1.1, which is brilliant. DeltaE basically indicates the error in the colour, as compared to what we see with our eyes, so the less the DeltaE, the more accurate the colours on a display. On smartphones, an average DeltaE of under 3 is considered very good so this is outstanding.

Coming to the 3000 nits brightness. This is one of the brightest displays that has come to any flagship so far. But does the iQOO 12 offer this level of luminance in real world scenarios? Nope! I tested the luminance using a Lux Meter on the iQOO 12, and the smartphone showcased a maximum luminance of 1653 nits under bright sunlight. Now, while this is far from the claimed numbers that iQOO has told us, but a peak luminance of over 1600 is outstanding for any smartphone, meaning the sunlight visibility is no issue at all.

Further, the 144Hz refresh rate makes this display an absolute delight to use. The iQOO 12 is outstanding in terms of responsiveness and while scrolling through social media and the UI, the iQOO 12's display is absolutely slick. This also comes into play while gaming. I was easily able to play games like Call of Duty Mobile and Battlegrounds Mobile India on 90FPS, giving me a fair advantage over my opponents during the gaming sessions.

So overall, this is a proper flagship display. Be it the vibrancy, the colour accuracy, the brightness, or the response rate. The iQOO 12's display is proper flagship-level and offers a decent improvement over the iQOO 11's display.

PERFORMANCE

Since this is an iQOO flagship, you'd think that performance is the main talking point. Well you're not too far off. While performance still takes a major chunk of the smartphone's personality, this time around the focus is somewhere else (refer to next subheading). This is the first